The Alliance

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Category:
Gen

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Netossa (She-Ra), Spinnerella (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
The Princess Alliance (She-Ra) - Freeform, Suicidal Ideation, Alternate Universe - Bloodborne Fusion, Don't Have to Know Bloodborne (Video Game), Adora Needs a Hug (She-Ra), Other Additional Tags to Be Added, slaps the top of Adora's head: this baby can hold so much trauma!, Adora Has Issues (She-Ra), Adora has PTSD - Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder (She-Ra), Adora Has Nightmares (She-Ra), Adora Has a Savior Complex (She-Ra), POV Adora (She-Ra)

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English

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Part 8 of Of the Blood, By the Blood

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by Nny11

Summary

Adora has struggled to move on after Catra and Weaver's deaths, and made one mistake that many do. Underestimating Frosta.

It's time to enter the Hunter's Dream and meet this so called Hunter's Alliance...

You've found yourself a hunter

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It’s funny, in a way. Adora would never have described herself as someone who had peaceful sleep, but she supposes you never really know what you have until you lose it. Without Catra at her back, it’s been less of a journey and more of a plummet to discovering how truly bad her rest could be. That said, there were complicating factors. She could’ve sworn that she’d just managed to dip into dreams when a pebble smacked into her backside and there was only one person she knew willing to do that to her.

“Frosta,” she half growled and half begged, “I need sleep.”

“And you’ve had it!”

Adora squeezed her eyes tighter together as if that would help things. Ha.

“You have had some sleep, dearie.”

Adora groaned and forced her bleary eyes open, even as they stung from dryness, to two sets of cheers. It took effort to push up onto her hands and knees, then shockingly more to tilt enough to sit on her butt. She looked nearly unseeing around the old Sh’ra Chapel as she valiantly tried to rejoin the waking world. It appeared Madam Razz, the chapel dweller here, had already started to set out the incense for the night; a few candles were even lit.

“Is it that late already?” She asked as Frosta handed her a flask with tea. Once upon a time she used to bring tonics. Adora was grateful the girl had listened when she pleaded for her to bring anything else. She herself had sworn off blood of any kind since-

“Yes.” Frosta said at the same time Razz sighed, “No, but they’re coming out sooner now. I saw one in broad daylight, hours before the sun had fully set!”

It was Madam Razz’s sworn duty to maintain the sanctity of the chapel, but just as important to the old crone was her desire to provide a safe haven for any who had nowhere else to go. Not that many had availed themselves to her services. Not that there were many left to do so.

Adora’s head ached as she drank slowly, her brain felt like it was twisting in on itself and stars danced behind her eyes. She needed to focus on something tangible, and her young friend was often delirious with ideas. “Ah. So, what’s the plan for today then?”

Frosta was young, too young for this sort of work really, but Etheria was done for. Some days it felt like there were no humans left alive and someone like Frosta, fresh, determined, and skilled could not be turned away. One more mark against the horrible city. They’d met that fateful night when Adora lost... everything. Frosta had been separated from her parents, she never said how but it was obvious from her rage against the grifters and scammers claiming they could get citizens outside the city walls for a price. All Adora knew for certain is that she saved the girl, and ten minutes later Frosta used a scavenged gun to save Adora’s life in turn. They’d mostly stuck together since then.

Mostly.

Adora frowned as a hand drawn map with instructions was rolled out on the floor of the chapel, forcing a smile as Razz gave her a half eaten and stone cold meat pie to eat. “I’m not part of your alliance.”

“I know, but hear me out!” Frosta rolled her eyes, huffing as if Adora had personally insulted her. Maybe she had.

The Hunter’s Alliance was a relatively new faction, a sponge that seemed to soak up the remnants of every local badge and even a

few Hordsemen who'd turned coat. It wasn't that they did poor work, that was solid. They were quickly becoming recognized as the only competent and compassionate hunters left possibly on the planet. What Adora could not stand was the arrogance and sometimes near obliviousness of the lot. Despite their skill and prowess, they had yet to retake a single section of the city, and without that, there was nowhere for regular citizens to be safe and that was beginning to wear them all out.

Etheria sprang into a nervous frenzy every morning, the few remaining shops and vendors making due from sunrise until the early afternoon, some closing before a mid day meal was even eaten. And then all rushed to their safe havens, few lived alone anymore thanks to the incense running low. So they crammed together in silent crowds, single doorways on entire city blocks marked with their pink smoke to cower against the dark.

Adora could only fear what this alliance would want in exchange for their services, or what their true end goal was if not protection. The Prospectors had been well known swindlers and cheats, the Church was nothing but the lazy and rich playing at hunting, and no one local was left. Did they want money? Land? What could they possibly be demanding that was so high a price that no one would scrap it together to give them in thanks?

No. She didn't like it. And she didn't much like them either. Hiding away somewhere safe and well fed, well rested, well kitted, and invitation only. How fortunate for them.

"You know I don't-"

"Look, Spinny and Netty are coming whether you want to come or not, but I'd really like it if you'd come with us! We could always use another hunter!" Despite the punch in Frosta's words, her shoulders curved up in caution towards her ears as if ready to be yelled down.

Grand. Two strangers at the chapel. Adora sighed and looked back at the map with a wince. Plumeria had once been the agricultural

center of Etheria, but they'd done poorly at containing the initial outbreak in response to the Healing Horde's horrific methods of "prevention". Now Plumeria lay abandoned, home to the ghosts and beasts left to freely roam within the sealed entrance. It was a death trap to anyone, and there was little reason to go and hunt there at all.

"Our time would be better spent thinning the beasts around the northern border." Adora muttered to herself, only to wince as Frosta flinched at the feedback. She sighed, gentling her voice, "I only mean that there is news of people still trapped up there, they could use our help to escape south into some of the wards that aren't as overrun."

"There's always false reports of people up there, same as Mystacor and Brightmoon." The girl grumbled back as she glared at the map. "This is a better use of your time if you'd let me finish."

"Whoa, hey there pipsqueak, what did I say about starting without us?"

Adora was on her feet, hand on the hilt of her sword before she could think. The stranger watched her warily, her own stance shifting from a casual walk to balance on the balls of her feet. For a tense moment they both waited before Adora moved her hand away slowly, assured the stranger was no beast and no drunkard.

The stranger sighed and stepped further forward into the faint candle light. It was no wonder she'd blended in so well. Her clothes were dark wool with leather reinforcements, her white hair carefully tucked into her black brimmed hat. With her dark skin and painted weapons she was nearly invisible in the dark. Even the beast bones strapped to her forearms had been blackened. Her smile was brilliant in comparison, eyes crinkling with good humor even if Adora could feel her sizing her up.

She held out her half gloved hand, "Sorry to scare you, forgot that I can be damn quiet when I want to be. I'm Netossa, and you

must be the Adora we keep hearing about."

Adora glanced down at Frosta who coughed and spun on her heels to help Madam Razz light the rest of the incense.

"Don't know about 'the', but yes, I'm at least an Adora." The handshake was awkward, Adora squeezing too tight then too light before almost yanking her hand back. Her skin crawled from the brief skin contact. "Sorry. I don't, uhm, socialize much. Anymore. I used to. Kind of. A normal amount I think. Lived with people and everything. Not that Madam Razz isn't a person, she is! I just mean- uh, sorry."

Just another nail in her self isolation coffin at this rate.

"Ah, don't worry about it," Netossa chuckled but took a respectable half step back, "we've got some real characters in the Alliance and I promise you're tame in comparison. At least so far. I'll let you know if you get to Entrapta levels."

"Entrapta levels?" Adora asked only for a set of footsteps to halt her. These were more purposeful and Adora was rather sure if the new hunter hadn't wanted to be heard, she would've been as silent as a breeze. "Your friend?"

Netossa's smile softened as she turned. "My wife, actually."

The woman who stepped out of the shadows still blanketing the entrance was the polar opposite. Larger in every way and dressed in light colored cottons with dull ring armor on top. Her left leg, however, lacked the protection to allow for two belts instead. An old superstition back when they thought the scourge infected up the left leg from the dirty streets. Just as old fashioned, a beast cutter hung on her shoulder, well cared for from what she could see.

"Darling, don't be mean." The woman chided, kissing Netossa's cheek in greeting.

Adora instantly hated them both. She felt horrible for it, but she couldn't help it.

"I'm not, I was being very nice and assuring Adora here about being normal by giving a clear comparison!" Netossa barely paused at her partner's dry look before scrambling on. "And Adora, this is Spinnerella, the last of our little hunting party for the night."

"I see." This time when Adora turned to glare at Frosta the younger girl almost melted behind the fragrant oil pots and found a reason to linger where all the wicks were already lit. "I was just explaining to Frosta that I don't like this plan."

The two women looked at one another in confusion before Spinnerella smiled and Netossa rolled her eyes. In tandem they asked, "Not your idea?"

"My idea? Why- … Frosta. I told you I'm **not** interested."

Too far. That was a step too far!

"And I said you should hear me out tonight and you didn't let me explain anything before saying it was stupid!"

Adora sighed as Frosta stomped over, and reminded herself that Frosta was still a kid. Not even a teen yet. "I didn't say it was stupid."

"It's how you said it." She snatched her map back up off the floor and pushed past her fellow hunters towards the doors. "We should get going while it's light. Good luck with the border, Adora."

She knew, logically, that Frosta had actually hunted more with these two women than they had ever done so together. Adora had been horrified by her desire to help initially, refused to help her learn, tried to make her stay put and be safe at the chapel, and inadvertently pushed her right into the alliance's arms. They were colleagues of a sort, but she couldn't say what they'd want from working with a child, and was loath to let them leave her sight.

So Adora grit her teeth as she jogged after them, "I never said no, I made a suggestion for an alternative."

"That's the same as saying no!'

Adora squinted as the late afternoon sun hit her eyes, hissing as she emerged into sunlight for the first time in… in far too long. "It wasn't meant to be- look, just explain it to me now, on the way, okay?"

"So you are coming then?" Netossa asked.

"Yes." Adora cleared her throat as if that would ease the bite of her answer. "I'm coming."

"Seriously!?" Frosta squealed, turning to quickly run and hug her before whipping her map back out to show her as they walked. "Thank you! You won't regret this, I promise!!"

Oh she regretted plenty as the explanation was given.

As she'd guessed they were scouting Plumeria for potential future rehabilitation and agriculture. Etheria was slowly starving, no one from outside dared approach the city with food, medicine, or clean water. Not with the scourge having fully matured now, the few cases outside the city had been contained without spread. The last thing she'd heard from a fleeing outsider had been a curse on the depravity of Etherians. She'd listened through doors to the laughter of those who cheered for her death; apparently she was too stupid to live according to them. Adora was sure that outside proper was probably worse, blaming Etherians for the spread of the disease and their addictions as if their own habits were pure. So there was merit to the idea. But only the idea.

Plumeria was still sealed tight, and breaking that seal could lead to the large number of beasts that freely roamed the streets to escape. Personally, Adora thought a second burning might be in order, perhaps even a third. The beasts that were left starved too, and ravenous and blood starved beasts could be far more dangerous than their well fed and blooded peers.

So, the day and then night were wasted on hours of nothing. The worthless checking and head counting and note taking on behaviors of every beast they could spy on Plumeria's streets. The only saving graces were that these beasts had been turned long enough to no longer speak, and that Netossa and Spinnerella had their own monoculors to speed the process along.

By the third hour Adora could feel the itch under her skin to enter the township proper. There was nothing more soothing to a hunter than the hunt itself. Razz had called it their false communion, although she'd refused to explain further. Adora felt fully awake and the old guilt and anxiety gnawed away at her. Killing a few beasts would do her good, shake the last of the haze, but no. She had to sit still instead and play out this farce.

That was rather cruel and rude, wasn't it? She was just… tired, not physically, but tired nonetheless.

"When's the last time you took a break from the hunt?" Spinnerella asked when they met back up from their teams of two to report out and eat a quick meal.

Adora had laughed, a bit too hard and too loud, but apparently that had been answer enough.

"You know, you could come to our base if you need a safe place to sleep. I know the chapel is warded but our workshop is truly fool-proofed against the scourge." Netossa was the one who'd offered. "You don't have to join us for that, it took us a few visits ourselves before we were willing to do anything even slightly related to the alliance. Trust me, I get where you're coming from on that one. Glimmer, she's the big boss, isn't all that concerned with public perception so much as results."

Adora had grunted to show she'd heard and was dismissing the offer, and they went out for their last looks. The whole mission finished out by two in the morning and the four of them met under the subdued light of their portable lanterns.

“Okay, that’s good then. Frosta, why don’t you report back to Glimmer directly?” Spinnerella handed her notebook over with a knowing look.

“Really? You mean it?” And that was the one good thing that had truly come from this night, was Frosta’s appreciation. Adora could only pray it would amount to something in the end.

“Your mission, your report, kid. We’ll catch up, got something to do ourselves first.” Spinnerella had barely waited until Frosta disappeared around a corner before turning to stop Adora from following. “No. If you want to see our headquarters, we can show you how to find it, but Frosta can handle delivering the report on her own.”

“What if something happens? Beasts could be anywhere in this darkness!” Adora hissed, trying to shove past only to find Netossa now there too.

“Adora, she’s young, but she isn’t stupid. And neither are we. The lamp is just around the corner we’ll be able to hear-”

Her blood sang with powerful magic, something ancient and arcane awakening for just a few seconds. Her ears rang with odd chimes and bells and wind. Gods, what kind of horrible powers did this alliance harbor? Adora had walked that street countless times and never seen anything that could cause such a reaction. But her bewilderment was mistaken fully.

“See, she’s home safe and didn’t need to feel like we didn’t trust her. Now, I think the real question is what the hell are you doing?”

Adora blinked rapidly, pulling back in confusion. “Excuse me?”

But the friendly and laid back Netossa had apparently vanished with Frosta. “You heard me. You’re clearly skilled, I can feel the arcane power rolling off you, Frosta’s said you don’t need healing blood like the rest of us, and yet you are still out here playing, what, big bad lone hunter?”

The anger growled in her chest, and Adora could only wonder if this is what Catra had felt before turning. “I’m trying to actually help people.”

Netossa snorted, waving a hand, “By, what, hunting a few beasts each night? What good does that do? We KNOW that hunting alone won’t fix this!”

A few beasts? A few beasts!?

“I have slain HUNDREDS-” But she didn’t even get a chance to respond as Spinnerella stepped in.

Calmly, like she was talking to a scared animal, “And we’ve killed thousands. We’ve been hunting since before you were born, Adora. Trust us when we say it’s not enough.”

“Oh that’s rich,” Adora laughed just to keep from screaming, “and your precious alliance hides away somewhere perfectly safe and hidden but you can’t bring anyone with you who you can’t use! Yes, I think I’ll trust you arrogant strangers quite well now, thanks!”

The two glanced at each other before Spinnerella spoke, “We can’t bring just anyone back, it doesn’t work like that.”

“How convenient for you. You scalp hunters from the streets, hide away in small safe numbers, claim to want to help, and then what? What is your price for helping? Because from what I can see it’s too damn high to waste FOUR hunters on simple scouting!” The anger slithered around her heart. “So do excuse my rudeness, *madam hunters* , but unlike you I am still living out here with the people I swore to protect. And every damn night I AM protecting them and then I tell them of a true safe haven where they can flee to if they need it.”

“You say that like we don’t care, when we do- we do everything we can!” Netossa shouted back.

Catra's glowing yellow eye flashed in her mind. Weaver's collapsed pupils glared from somewhere deeper in her soul.

"Well it's not enough, so don't pretend you're better than me just because I prefer to work hands on with those who can't fight for themselves."

There was a long pause before Netossa huffed, small and sad for the anger still in her voice. "And I ask you again, what good is it truly doing? How long do they live before another beast gets them? One woman cannot save Etheria, not alone. We do have a plan, we've let you in on it, and yes it's big. It's ambitious. But we are trying to save the city too, and we're telling you right now-"

Spinnerella spoke over her, "We've done what you're doing, and someday soon, the exhaustion will overtake you. Dying won't save them."

"You don't know that!" Adora froze, the air hanging silent around them. "That's not- I'm not-"

"We've all been there, kid." Netossa took a half step forward and stopped when Adora stumbled backwards. She prayed for a beast to come crawling out of the shadows, but none came when she needed them. "You can only hunt for so long before you lose hope. No hope, and then what's the point? I don't know who you lost, but I know it wasn't your fault."

She laughed, the tears falling thick down her cheeks as she collapsed against the old brickwork wall behind her. "It was, though. It was."

How many times had Catra begged to leave? How many times had she come up with plans to save them both? How much love she had given away for pain and an empty promise and now she was gone. Gone, gone, gone.

"I'm sorry to hear that." Spinnerella looked away, eyes glassy and unfocused. "I've- there was- I… I'm sorry, Adora. I am. Would

they want you to die for it, or would they be grateful you killed them?”

“Both- neither! I don’t know, I don’t- I don’t know.”

Pathetic and horrible, to cry at the feet of two women who stood for all she had grown to hate, and to wish to be them more than anything. Catra would’ve said to not trust them, but she also would’ve been the first to place unearned trust into their hands. Catra would’ve at least taken the offer to see this safe place, better to know and not need than need and not know. Adora had resigned herself to death but been too scared or too proud to take it, always one more night, one more person, one more beast.

In her memories, Catra laughed at her for scrubbing the clinic floor so intently from one of the surgery tables. She'd snickered, “Weaver won’t notice and the patients are too desperate to care. Take a break while you can, I say!”

Spinnerella crouched down cautiously, signaling her movements and going slowly before offering her hand. “Please.”

Adora’s heart thundered in her ears as she took the woman’s hand, firm and shockingly strong, and was hauled back to her feet. Without another word the three of them went around the corner and Adora sighed as she saw nothing new.

Netossa walked ahead stopping and pointing at the ground. Her blood sang, vision blurred, and then there was a lamp, hung from an ancient bit of metal and tied to it with bells and bows. It didn’t appear, it didn’t fade into existence. One moment it had not been there, and the next it always had been. Adora scoured her memories and found in each one she could see it clearly, in fact she’d made it a point to never walk on that side of the street before. A habit born from vision-less sight.

“What is it?” Adora asked, before hurrying on, “Besides a lamp, I got that far.”

“Why don’t you come closer and see?” Netossa challenged before she knelt and something bubbled up from under the ground.

No, that wasn’t right, it- the white and blue gray bodies crawled up and around one another to hold the lamp up. Malformed faces and withered dead bodies; desiccated remains that still smiled without teeth and some without mouths or eyes. Just as before Adora knew in her heart they had always been there, simply unseen until they pulled themselves through the cobblestone underfoot. Netossa smiled down at them, reached her hand out and stilled as several tiny hands gripped the tips of fingers- and then she faded as the bells tolled.

“Angels!”Adora felt a wave of vertigo hit as she realized she’d seen statues all across Etheria depicting this. Ancient statues showing the small, almost skeletal creatures that held a crooked purple lamp. Far more ancient that the scourge even. What was this? What had they discovered that the church had not? Weaver had called them demons, sent to drag them into the afterlife, but Catra had whispered to her about the angels. “You have the ears of the angels!?”

Spinnerella smiled, almost childish with her glee, “We call them the messengers, but yes! Do you see now why we can’t bring everyone with us? Poor little babes would be overwhelmed.”

Adora knelt to look more closely, then leaned back nervously as they turned to reach out to her. They moaned and stretched, the occasional fang flashed and their long pointed ears fluttered. Their focus didn’t even shift as Spinnerella knelt with her, the power radiating off of them soothing instead of grating.

“I’m not surprised that they like you,” she chuckled wiggling her fingers like one might to entice a cat to attack over their heads without effect. “The little ones tend to like a good lost cause, it’s how they found all of us as well. …when you’re ready touch their hands and think of safety, whatever that means for you. I’ll be right behind.”

She wavered then cracked under the weight of their gummy smiles, cautiously reaching out as she tried to picture safety.

There was the chapel, of course, cozy and warm and filled with light and smoke. There was Madam Razz with food and drink, and a smile to chase away even the darkest of nights. It wasn't quite enough, she could feel the power reaching out to her but not connecting. Adora swallowed hard, staring in desperation at the small creatures, scared for reasons she couldn't understand that they would reject her. She tried to reach out, to connect without it, but the power came no closer. So, instead, Adora squeezed her eyes shut and pictured two tone eyes, a sharp smile and sharper tongue, of a rough and squeaky voice whispering assurance to her in the darkness.

And when she opened her eyes she was kneeling in a field of flowers.

Chapter End Notes

> Why, yes! Instead of the messengers being unborn/stillborn babies, they are now unborn/stillborn clones! This wording makes sense, I- uh- promise?

Embolden your sickly spirit

Chapter Summary

Adora arrives where she's always been meant to be.

“Hello, good hunter!”

Adora turned slowly, her mind still reeling and overwhelmed with ancient and powerful magic. There was a man who stood a decent ways away, probably to protect himself in case she snapped in the transference. Angels. She’d been brought to the other side- to the after life? Or a different life? Gods be good!

“It is okay if you are scared, many are the first they come.” The man smiled, chuckling brightly before winking.

“I- what- who are you?” Too many questions, she had too many questions.

“I am an automaton.” When he smiled this time Adora gasped as the metal plates making up his face shifted to let him smile. How had she not noticed that he was made of metal and wood? “My creator named me Wrong Hordak. I believe for obvious reasons. What and who are you?”

Obvious? No, she didn’t think so. And the way he spoke- the way he asked… A child. He was child-like in many ways. A metal child. Sure. Why not? Angels had taken her to a place no living soul should be, and she could humor such strangeness under that lens.

“Uhm, I’m a human? And my name’s Adora.”

Wrong Hordak tilted his head in consideration, his voice oddly calm and sure as he probed, “Are you quite sure?”

Her eyes fluttered with her confusion, her heart twisted and untwisted. “I- yes!?”

“Hey, buddy, thank you! I’ve got her from here!”

When Adora leaned to see if the newest speaker was also made of metal, she was relieved to see a human man, and then left wondering once more as she realized that among the white and gold and browns of his clothes there was a burnt red love heart over his chest. Alright, human, but odd enough.

Wrong Hordak bowed, “Of course Hunter Bow! Possible human Adora, please let me know if there is anything I can do for you while you remain here in the hunter’s dream.”

“I am a human! Just for the record!” Adora stumbled as she stood too quickly. “Not a beast, I promise!”

Bow’s smile relaxed, becoming softer and kinder as he looked at her directly. “I know, Frosta speaks highly of you and Netossa already vouched. We thought you’d appear by the workshop, so we’d sent Wrong Hordak away to introduce you once you got your feet under you, so to speak. He can be a bit much, as you no doubt understand already.”

She gave a humorless laugh and asked, “Workshop?”

Bow nodded and jerked his head over his shoulder, guiding them both along a small trail in the flowers around the trees and hills that circled the meadow. “Yes, it was made to look like the old Horde Workshop, give us the tools and space we need somewhere safe. Glad we could bring you here, not everyone is willing to trust the arcane arts or strangers.”

No. She supposed they wouldn’t.

She wasn’t sure she did either, but what was done was done, a psychopomp had whisked her away and she was unsure how to return without the very hunters she detested. “Can you blame them?”

Bow’s smile turned sad, but his eyes were far too knowing as he said, “No, and we wouldn’t blame you either.”

The rest of the walk wasn't long, the hill barely passed before she saw the large building looming overhead on another small hill. If that had been all there was, she wouldn't have paused. But the sky beyond the workshop made something in her very bones freeze.

They were on an island of sorts. Floating, but perhaps not. As far as the eye could see there were strange pillars made of wood and stone and metal- not combined, just each on its own- and not shifting between them. Much like the lamp and the messengers as she stared, the pillars had always been whatever she saw now. Metal, now stone, now wood. They stretched into the sky until they vanished entirely into the gently shifting waves of golden water.

"Welcome to the hunter's dream. We created this place to have somewhere safe to work from, somewhere the beasts can't reach and blood drunk hunters can't find."

The air reeked of moonlight, sickly sweet and acidic and soft. Her head buzzed as she stared above them. For one moment she saw the remains of the orphanage, a small beast huddled under the stairs and a horrifically large beast that prowled in front. The water rippled and she could see the streets of Central Etheria, the grand cathedral, a cramped city square, the clock tower- and beyond all of it something slithered in the golden light.

Bow gently took her elbow and pulled her a little on. "Best not to look too long, it's not for us to know."

Adora blinked, shook her head, forced her eyes down and her blood stopped singing. Just in time too, although she couldn't say why exactly.

"Adora!!" Frosta shouted, louder than ever as she rushed forward as if to hug her before skidding to a halt. "You made it!"

"Yes, it's… it's a lot."

"I felt that way the first time myself."

Adora's head whipped around to stare at another stranger, a woman dressed in nearly rags. The grey and green and brown shifted like hair, in fact, if the woman's face wasn't plainly visible Adora would have assumed her to be a beast. Long blonde hair fell over her shoulders in braids, her deep brown eyes a tad too understanding.

"I'm Perfuma. Thank you, for looking into Plumeria, for checking on her people."

Adora frowned as she thought back over the dull vigil. "I- of course, but I saw no people?"

Frosta winced, waving a hand over her throat where she couldn't be seen. And Perfuma frowned fiercely.

"In case you've failed to realize, those things you hunt are not beasts, but people."

Bow glanced nervously between them and Frosta mouthed apologies as she began to slink away. Blood thundered in her ears, and Adora couldn't help but laugh. Loud and perhaps crazed. People. Ha!

"How dare you?" Adora gasped as she tried to gather her control again. "How stupid do you think I am? How blind are you!? **How dare you** - people! Yes, they were ONCE people."

If she was off put or bothered, Perfuma did nothing more to show it. "They still are."

"No." Adora wiped tears from her eyes, grin frozen in place. "I've spoken with them, not at them, do you understand? I've spoken with one of them. Twisted. Not human. Not anymore I'm afraid."

Her hands shook and Adora prayed for all their sakes that that would be the end of it.

"As have I." Perfuma's voice was firm despite how softly she spoke, nearly a whisper. "Humans are not all good, the horrible

truth is that many are monsters. Monstrous people become monstrous 'beasts', but so do good people I'm afraid. I've spoken at length with the ones left by the church, and do you know what they speak of? Mercy. For assurance, succor. They forget, much as the elderly can, they forget when and where they are. But they are still who they always were. Claws, pulsating skulls, and all."

There was a pause as Adora tried to understand what insanity had taken this woman, grinding her heart into dust as it leapt with old guilt and new fears. What did she mean that she had spoken with MANY beasts? That they were sedate or contained enough to seek comfort and love? How long did it take for them to be as such? Or had she simply been careless in her broken hearted fear and missed it? Perhaps Catra had said something as she died, a plea for Adora, her last words lost forever. She could not think on it. She took the feelings and shoved them down, deep below the waters to drown.

"My apologies, I did not mean to start a fight on your arrival. I only wished to thank you for checking on my people, regardless of your feelings towards them. I'll be on my way for now. I wish you a dreamless sleep, Adora."

Perfuma turned, the suddenness betraying her emotions, and walked quickly to one of the hundreds of gravestones that lined the paths, the walls, the fences. As if every spare surface was made of them. As she knelt the messengers sprang forth. Cooing and gurgling as they grabbed her hand and whisked her away.

"Thank the gods," Bow sighed, "she's a good woman and a good hunter, but she is… sensitive as I'm sure you noticed when it comes to the hunt."

Adora huffed. "She's delusional."

Bow looked at her carefully, his face unreadable before turning back to the workshop. "Come, Glimmer is waiting for us."

More people. Gods how many were there? Adora craved a minute of silence, a moment to compose herself, but instead they walked up the path to the workshop itself. Bow pulled the heavy wooden door open and motioned inside with an unreadable smile.

She found herself holding her breath as she crossed the threshold and jumping as the door closed behind her.

The workshop was small, oddly narrow but long. Weapon blades and parts hung from the ceiling, the walls, and leaned in every spare inch they could find. Benches at the back hummed with power and reeked of blood, but it was barely noticeable over the smell of burning wood. Stairs led up and away on one side, and in front of them the fireplace crackled almost merrily. And there, a near supernova of the arcane blinded her as her blood sang in discordant tones.

"You must be the Adora our Frosta speaks so highly of."

The first several things that Adora clocked in rapid succession were the thick foreign accent, the haughty tone to the words, and the pure arcane magic spilling off of her. She could almost see it roll off of Glimmer's skin; viscous and smoke like everywhere that Adora doesn't look directly. It's so thick that her host's shadows leak the cosmos, even the underside of her hair sparkles with purples, pinks, and stars. All of it comes together in an awe inspiring way. All of it comes together in a horrible, heart wrenching thought. *This is what Weaver had hoped to be.* And that meant that Glimmer was dangerous.

Very dangerous.

"So I keep being told. Glimmer, I take it?"

Her smile was friendly but Adora knows the calculations running underneath.

"I did not expect you to be foreign as well," She finally rose from her chair, the feeling of power and control didn't lessen with her

heavy limp, although it did draw Adora's eye down to the peg leg poking out from her trousers.

"No? Many here seem to be from outside the city, why not me as well?"

Glimmer's eyes crinkled with genuine mirth even as she avoided the question. "Interesting, isn't it? Why do you think we have so few Etherians?"

Adora doesn't like her tone, but she liked the flashes of memories it instilled less. There's a cold truth she had come to understand, Etherians were worse off than anyone else in their own city. Expected to be everywhere, to do everything, to survive with a smile when they have less money, less influence, and less ability than the rich eccentrics who moved in did. She'd argued about this once with Catra, and like so many things Adora wished she could change that past. She could try now at least.

"They are dying in mass, madam, they can't afford weapons or training, they are the first to be abandoned. I do not find that interesting at all. I find that horrific."

Glimmer scoffed, "Perhaps they should spend less on blood then. Hard to save the rabble of drunks who fight against receiving aid."

It wasn't that Adora didn't agree, she did, but-

"Have you ever worked with them?" She asked instead of screaming. "Because I have. The true addicts of it, selling their dead's flesh and bone to get more. Those who were violent and cursed at me the whole time. The ones without jobs, or friends, or a home. The ones some called worthless."

"I take it you have an opinion on it then."

Adora gave a tight lipped smile. "Oh, yes. They're still worth saving, most of them more than any rich outsider."

She wasn’t sure what exactly she expected from her insult, but Glimmer throwing her head back to laugh was not high on it. But laugh she did. Full and deep, and the very air around her shimmered with visions of another place, another time, another life too fast to parse.

“Trust me when I tell you this: the only disagreement on that you’ll get from me is that the aristocracy should pave the very roads we walk so any drunk could piss on them.” Glimmer paused, head tilting before jerking her chin out. “Ah, the others are here. Good, let’s speak with the alliance then. Better to knock our heads together than against a wall.”

“Where in the hells do you all keep coming from!?” Adora hissed as they stepped outside to the small crowd that sat waiting by the steps up.

Glimmer laughed again, but instead of answering merely walked forward to introduce her.

May you find your worth in the waking world

Chapter Summary

Adora's secret becomes known and tested, something ancient is born.

Chapter Notes

CW: suicide

The meeting had been… she wanted to say chaotic, but that wasn't quite right. There was control, structure, and organization of it. Even with so many people presenting at the same time; at times speaking over one another to add information. It all flowed naturally enough. Busy. Crowded.

In addition to everyone she'd already met, Adora had been introduced to Sea Hawk, Mermista, and Entrapta. Each reporting on what they knew, each report giving Adora desperately needed and hated insight.

Beast grew more numerous on the coasts, even outside Etheria's walls. Sailing was now the only route for supplies being brought into the city as the main road was finally confirmed to be cut off. They were being killed slowly, the whole world turning on Etheria and her people. Hoping they died by the beasts and if not, would die from starvation and dehydration, from exposure and unsanitary conditions. Mermista had snorted when Bow lamented what that meant for the city, "Yeah, listen, people out there? They think we're all beasts anyways. Anyone who makes it out is being killed on the roads, burned in ditches to contain the spread. They don't care how long or brutal a death we die, as long as we're dead."

She hated the confirmation that nowhere was safe, and that even fleeing was no longer an option. She hated how the alliance accepted that fate. She hated not having another solution.

Entrapta reported that she'd finished installing more lamps for transport, all installed in the north of the city where she confirmed the reports of trapped humans to be half true. More limited survivors than any of them knew, and none of them were willing to leave their strongholds. The bulk of them had moved into the catacombs to increase their odds of survival.

Adora hated knowing that she'd been right and that she'd also been wrong. She hated how scared they all were. She hated that the maze of tunnels, once the most dangerous part of living in Etheria, were now safer than the streets. She hated the memories it brought of the basement.

Most of all she hated the way Entrapta had startled at her frustrated huffing before trying to explain, "Oh, sorry! I forgot you're new. See the labyrinth is real and-"

As if she was stupid. Only true outsiders believed them false, the average citizen knew very little beyond that. "I am very well aware. It's… bad memories."

"Oh? Have you been then?"

Adora grimaced, if Razz could force her down to communion she would've. Or perhaps Catra was right and she already had. "I grew up in the orphanage."

"That," Entrapta almost choked as she spoke, "is fascinating! I would love to get any information you have then, entrances, locations, beasts, portals, it all could help. The catacombs are safer than the streets these days."

Everyone stared at her and Adora hated the feeling of so many eyes crawling across her skin.

"Were you there when that kin was-"

"Entratpa," Glimmer spoke firmly, eyes cutting the poor hunter down where she stood, "Adora will share what she wishes to,

when she wishes to. If you have questions, ask when you are both on your own."

And now she was being coddled? This alliance made no sense! The hunters made no sense! The whole damn thing was- it was- and gods her head ached-

"The tentacled skeleton?" Adora asked, sighing heavily when Entrapta nodded hesitantly while looking at Glimmer as if she was afraid of the woman. Perhaps she should be afraid too. "Yes. That was Weaver, I was there when she… when she was chosen."

"Did you kill her?" It was Spinnerella who asked with far too much knowing. Too much kindness in her eyes.

"No. I couldn't- no. But after that? I took care of the other beast."

"What other beast?"

Adora's heart pounded in her throat causing her to laugh, a short, sharp sort of bark. "I wasn't the only orphan, until I was. She," gods forgive her she couldn't say her name, "t-the other girl, she'd had too much paleblood by then to save."

Spinnerella was reaching out, her hand barely lifted to comfort her the same way one might reach out to a cornered animal when Glimmer spoke again. "How in the world could a child have access to paleblood? Lord Prime guards it jealously."

"Weaver produced it, it was what made her blood special, the arcane power in her blood thinned it, turned it into something more. She tried to find a cure with it, but, well…"

"Addicted?"

"Not to it, but yes. The other, she was inert to most, she needed the purity to be healed."

This time it was Mermista who interrupted her. "Why does it matter if it was church blood, why would that do her in?"

The white all around her became almost blinding. Spinnerella's barely changed robes to Bow's armor to Glimmer's cape. Horde. Many of them were former Horde, no longer wearing their badge but having been lost in the system all the same. Exposed all the same. The dream felt constricting, like a noose tightening around her neck.

"Because it's tainted?" When everyone stared harder at her, Adora fumbled a bit as she realized they didn't know. Gods be good, **they didn't know.** How much had they-? "Drinking it is one thing, but the Horde, the blood supply they have is too strong. Too powerful, frankly, for most and that's what gives the injection its power to heal. But using it increases the chance you'll turn. It's- it's all from the blood. It's a blood illness."

"Wait." Mermista spoke slowly with a quaver in her voice, "You mean that any of us could turn because of the blood?"

Adora stared at her sadly and nodded. "I'm sorry."

The whole alliance burst into a buzzing cacophony of noise, terror pouring out. What if we turn here? "Stop." How long do you think we'll have? Is it based on the amount? "Stop!" Who's used the most of it? Who's used the most blood?

"STOP IT!" Adora screamed, too many emotions bashing against her battered heart. "A witch hunt is no better here than out there. You'll- you'll know. You'll feel the power of it coming, be stronger, be more hot headed."

"And how do you know that?" Mermista all but demanded, the glint in her eyes though-

Adora stared a moment too long into her too glossy eyes. Ah. Gods save them. "I've seen it first hand, didn't know what it was until much too late to purge it."

"So the rumors are true then." Glimmer's whisper swept over them all, the magic pulsed as it shed from her skin, evaporating

before touching the ground. It made her head shudder uncontrollably.

“What rumors?”

“Ah, a poor choice of words. It’s, hmm, the whispers of Sh’ra, do you understand that?”

Sh’ra. Adora’s stomach turned at the name. Catra had prayed to that god, not often but when she did it was with genuine fervor that not many would expect. A god of power, of protection, of vengeance. Weaver had scoffed over the popularity of Sh’ra with the masses who understood “less and little”, her own prayers turned towards Hemin or to The Daughter of the Cosmos. But even Minister Weaver did not profane the Sh’ra, moved them quickly past the statues of the mother and moon presence.

Adora bit her tongue, lest she say something she could not take back from this side of the veil. She hated Sh’ra most of all for failing, for the false promise of safety.

Glimmer huffed before lifting her hand, it glowed with a blinding golden light for a moment before dropping. “Ah! You can see that which is unseen. That is good. Sh’ra sustains this dream, and I am its caretaker, sometimes she shares with me. And I have heard healing and purge, but thought it was- it doesn’t matter what I’d thought it meant. It’s you? Isn’t it? You are the cure.”

Adora gave a brittle laugh. “If I could cure them I wouldn’t have- I would have-”

Catra’s claws burned in her flesh, tears drenched her hands, blood poured so freely over her blade. Weaver’s too long arms, grinning skull, the smiles filled with teeth.

“Tell me, how do you heal without the blood? Good old fashioned healing takes too long.”

“It’s my gift. Not blood, but arcane healing. It’s no cure. I tried, and she- it- it didn’t work.”

It’s Mermista who speaks again, slow and ragged. “Perhaps she was too far gone then, the girl you had to kill.”

Adora’s heart clenched. “And failed.”

“We don’t know why, there could be something you missed.” Mermista turned as if to ask the group for their support. None knew what to say, Glimmer stared at the golden light that danced across her finger tips once more. “She could have been too far gone. Well, I’m not. Not yet.”

“Beloved?” Sea Hawks’ voice cracked but she pulled from his grip to stalk forwards without him.

“I can feel it. Writhing inside me-” Mermista’s finger scratched down her arms. She swallowed hard, eyes unfocused. “It’s like a whisper you can’t ignore. If you’re correct, I’ll turn soon, we just don’t know when.”

“Mermista! No, it’s, perhaps it’s just-” Sea Hawk flailed for an answer, tears in his eyes. “Dearest, please, I love you!”

“Love isn’t enough.” Mermista didn’t even turn to look at him, her smile vicious at Adora instead. “Miss cure over here knows that already. But that’s okay, I don’t need you to love me, chosen girl. Try it on me. It can’t possibly do any more harm.”

Bells rang in her ears, a crackle and pop of static and sand, the singing of angels too high to hear. “No.”

Mermista laughed softly. “Fine. Your loss then. I won’t turn.”

It happened too quickly and too slowly. Adora saw the flash of something in Mermista’s hand, her first instinct made her step backwards to prepare to dodge, only to realize the blade was lifting up not out. Up and up and- she can only be grateful that Sea Hawk was behind Mermista when she dragged the knife across her own throat. Her hand shook with the effort to slice deeply, but it happened easily enough. And her blood, it smelled too sweet, it smelled of pure moonlight and sprayed a brackish

red too dark to be human. The alliance shouted as Mermista fell to her knees, and Adora was already dashing forward.

If Adora hadn't fucked this all up so badly, none of this would be happening.

Her and Catra would be living far away from the city. Or they would have at least had each other. Frosta would have found someone more stable to follow. They wouldn't have recruited her. She wouldn't be here. Mermista wouldn't know.

Mermista could've- *what* ? Something in her snarled. Died peacefully transforming without warning in the dream? Damn her! Damn them all!

Fury takes over, but it is filled with the warmth of concern and caring. Golden light poured off of her and blue sparks danced in her vision as she poured herself into healing. That happened easily enough, almost too quickly, too route despite how long it had been since she'd healed another person.

For one second she holds a corpse. Then a scared woman. Then- then- the monster shrieked at her, slug-like and drooping, withdrawing into its shell as it burst into flames. And then they both sat on the ground shaking too hard to move.

Sea Hawk flung himself into Mermista's arms, hauling her bodily back to try and help only to find the wound healed.

Glimmer stared down at Adora both thoughtful and smug, and she knew in her very bones that she had both passed and failed some sort of test.

Glimmer limped closer, kneeling to drop to her height. "Can you do it for all of us then? We've all partaken. And if that's what could have been, is it not worth it to try? Or perhaps we need to ritually kill ourselves, I'm sure there's some ritual for it."

"No, I can- it's hard." Her head spun, the world rocked underfoot. "It's draining."

“Then we keep a few vials for emergencies. Rest first, then we can see what can be done. Entrapta, when she’s ready see what you can learn, perhaps we can find a way to replicate it. Ease the burden. And, Adora, whenever you are ready, I can teach you control.”

Minister Weaver had once made such a promise, and the returns had been fruitless. But Weaver had not had the ear of a god.

Mermista’s gasps had calmed, the whole of the alliance turned to her when Glimmer gave Adora a simple badge with a shining sword as its emblem. The whispered order to return soon was both a plea and demand. But the pointed finger back to the field of flowers is nothing but a god send.

Adora stumbled barely making it around the corner before she collapsed at the foot of the tombstone Perfuma had used earlier. No angels rise to greet her. She wondered if that was some sort of sign.

“Ah, good hunter, I see you are lost, please allow me to assist you.” Wrong Hordak walked forward too silent for a man made of metal, kneeling on the ground by her. The messengers burst from the ground to grasp at his hands and knees. Adora wondered if he had once been a messenger too, an angel that found grounding, it would make sense to her.

“Ah, the little ones, inhabitants of the dream. They find hunters like yourself to worship and serve. They do not speak words, but still, aren’t they sweet? They rest here at these memorials. Countless hunters have visited this dream, the graves here stand in their memory, although it was so long ago now…” His smile faded with his voice, overtaken by his own thoughts.

Adora watched wearily, from what Glimmer and Bow had said this dream had not been active for more than a few years at the most. Although she supposed that to one so young, it must seem quite long indeed.

“Apologies, I must have drifted off.” Wrong Hordak gasped, eyes fluttering although they never fully closed, and then he chuckled. “Then again, so did you in a manner. Please, let these little ones take you back, think of the lamp you wish to return to and let this be nothing more than a sweet dream.”

“That’s it, simply wake up?” Adora had been horrible at sleeping, but waking had never been much trouble. Wrong Hordak smiled widely again, and at his silent nodding she reached out. Her stomach dropped, the bells rang softly, and she heard the false man murmur.

“Oh Sh’ra, of the moons, of the dreams- Oh little ones, fleeting will of the ancients- let the hunter be safe. Let her find comfort, and let this dream, her captor… foretell a pleasant awakening and be, one day, a fond, distant memory.”

And when she opened her eyes, she was in her usual spot in the chapel. Slowly sitting up amongst the candles and the incense with Madam Razz watching her thoughtfully, a smile cracking around her ancient face. “Good to have you back, dearie. Wasn’t sure if it was your time yet!”

Adora did not answer, only sat in the silence of the chapel as the night fell over them once more.

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